

# When Elders Disagree

*Navigating Conflict, Dissent, and Division on the Elder  
Team*

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**JAMES BELL**

When Elders Disagree

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# Contents

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|                                                      |    |
|------------------------------------------------------|----|
| WHEN ELDERS DISAGREE .....                           | 1  |
| WHEN ELDERS DISAGREE                                 |    |
| Introduction: The Meeting Nobody .....               | 2  |
| Tells You About                                      |    |
| Introduction: The Meeting Nobody Tells You About     |    |
| The Inevitability and Goodness of .....              | 4  |
| Elder Disagreement                                   |    |
| The Inevitability and Goodness of Elder Disagreement |    |
| Common Sources of Elder Conflict .....               | 10 |
| Common Sources of Elder Conflict                     |    |
| How to Disagree Well .....                           | 16 |
| How to Disagree Well                                 |    |
| When an Elder Becomes an Opponent .....              | 23 |
| When an Elder Becomes an Opponent                    |    |
| Making Decisions When Elders Are .....               | 29 |
| Divided                                              |    |
| Making Decisions When Elders Are Divided             |    |
| Rebuilding After Elder Conflict .....                | 35 |
| Rebuilding After Elder Conflict                      |    |

Conclusion: The Unity That Is Worth ..... 41  
Fighting For  
    Conclusion: The Unity That Is Worth Fighting For

# WHEN ELDERS DISAGREE

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**NAVIGATING CONFLICT, DISSENT, AND Division** on the  
Elder Team

Pastors Connection Network

[pastorsconnectionnetwork.com](http://pastorsconnectionnetwork.com)

# Introduction: The Meeting Nobody Tells You About

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**NOBODY WARNS YOU ABOUT** the elder meeting where everything falls apart.

You know the one. You have probably already been in it, or you are heading toward it. It is the meeting where a decision you thought was settled gets reopened. Where a man you considered a genuine partner reveals he has been quietly building a case against the direction you are leading. Where two elders who have been cordial in public suddenly surface months of accumulated grievance. Where the room goes cold, voices rise, and the men who are supposed to be your team start functioning more like opposing counsels.

Elder conflict is among the most disorienting experiences in pastoral ministry. It is disorienting because it catches you off guard — you expected disagreement with the congregation, but not with the men you thought were fighting

This book is an attempt to provide what most pastoral training does not. Not a conflict avoidance strategy — elder disagreement is not avoidable, and attempting to avoid it produces teams that are falsely united rather than genuinely healthy. Not a conflict resolution formula — the complexity of real elder relationships does not yield to formulaic approaches. But a theological framework for understanding why disagreement happens and why it is not inherently bad, a set of practical principles for navigating it well, and an honest account of what to do when the conflict is not just disagreement but genuine opposition.

The elder team that learns to disagree well becomes one of the most powerful assets in the congregation's life. The elder team that cannot disagree well — that either suppresses conflict until it explodes, or allows it to fracture the team's unity and effectiveness — becomes one of the most significant threats to the congregation's health.

The path between those two outcomes runs through the content of this book.

How good and pleasant it is when brothers dwell in unity!  
— Psalm 133:1

## CHAPTER ONE

# The Inevitability and Goodness of Elder Disagreement

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**WHY THE ABSENCE OF** conflict is not the same as the presence of health

There is a pastoral fantasy about elder teams that does enormous damage to real elder teams. It is the fantasy of frictionless unity — the picture of a group of godly men who, by virtue of their shared faith and shared calling, agree with each other about everything and work together without conflict, tension, or disagreement.

This fantasy is not just unrealistic. It is unbiblical. The New Testament does not present the early church's leadership as a conflict-free zone. It presents it as a community where genuine disagreement happened, was addressed, and was sometimes resolved and sometimes not. Paul and Peter clashed publicly in Antioch over a matter of genuine theological importance. Paul and Barnabas



If the apostles disagreed, your elder team will disagree too. The question is not whether disagreement will happen, but what kind of disagreement it will be and how it will be handled.

## THE BIBLICAL CASE FOR PRODUCTIVE DISAGREEMENT

**THE NEW TESTAMENT'S VISION** of plural eldership is grounded in a conviction that diverse gifts and perspectives, held together under the lordship of Christ, produce better oversight than any one man could provide alone. Paul describes the body of Christ in 1 Corinthians 12 as a community where different gifts — not the same gift operating in different people, but genuinely different gifts — are essential to the whole. What the eye sees, the ear does not. What the hand can do, the foot cannot. The diversity is not a liability. It is a design.

Apply this to the elder team and the implication is significant. A team of men with different gifts, different backgrounds, different temperaments, and different areas of pastoral insight will see the congregation's needs from different angles. One elder notices the theological drift that another has not identified. One elder has pastoral relationships with the families that another does not. One elder brings institutional wisdom that another lacks. One elder asks the uncomfortable question that everyone else was

This diversity is not the cause of conflict. It is the reason the team is more effective than any individual would be. And the disagreement that emerges from that diversity — when it is handled with honesty, respect, and genuine openness — is not a sign of dysfunction. It is a sign that the team is actually using its diversity rather than suppressing it.

### WHEN HARMONY BECOMES GROUPTHINK

**THERE IS A SPECIFIC** kind of elder dysfunction that looks like exceptional health from the outside. The team is harmonious. Meetings run smoothly. Decisions are made quickly and without drama. The pastor never faces significant pushback from his elders. Everyone appears to be on the same page.

This can be genuine health. But it can also be groupthink — the suppression of legitimate dissent by a culture that has made agreement the primary value and disagreement the primary social risk. And in the context of an elder team, groupthink is dangerous.

The elder team that does not genuinely disagree is not exercising its oversight function. It is rubber-stamping. The decisions that need to be challenged are not being challenged. The questions that should be asked are not being asked. The perspectives that would catch what the dominant voice is missing are being withheld because the culture has communicated — explicitly or implicitly — that the cost of raising them is higher than the benefit of offering them.

How does this culture develop? Sometimes it is the result of a dominant personality on the team — a senior pastor or a longtime elder whose social authority is sufficient to

Whatever its source, groupthink on an elder team is a slow-moving crisis. The problems it is not catching do not disappear because they are not being named. They grow. And when they finally surface — when the theological drift becomes undeniable, when the pastoral failure becomes visible, when the financial irregularity comes to light — the team discovers that the silence that felt like health was actually the absence of the watchfulness it was designed to provide.

### THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN DESTRUCTIVE AND PRODUCTIVE CONFLICT

**NOT ALL DISAGREEMENT IS** created equal. The goal of this book is not to produce more conflict on elder teams. It is to produce better conflict — conflict that is honest and direct, that is motivated by love for the congregation and commitment to the mission, that is engaged with genuine openness to being wrong, and that is resolved in ways that strengthen rather than fracture the team.

Destructive conflict is characterized by personalizing the disagreement, by pursuing influence rather than truth, by using information strategically rather than sharing it openly, and by treating the resolution of conflict as a victory to be won rather than a truth to be found. Destructive conflict damages relationships, produces decisions that reflect power

Productive conflict is characterized by intellectual honesty, by the willingness to separate the issue from the person, by genuine curiosity about what the other perspective might be seeing that yours is not, and by the shared commitment to the congregation's good as the standard by which disagreements are resolved. Productive conflict strengthens relationships, produces better decisions, and creates a team culture in which men trust each other enough to be honest with each other.

The path from destructive to productive conflict is not primarily a matter of technique. It is primarily a matter of character and culture. The chapter that follows addresses the common sources of elder disagreement. But the chapters after that are about the kind of men and the kind of team that can handle disagreement in a way that makes it productive rather than destructive.

#### REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Think of the last significant disagreement on your elder team. Was it productive or destructive? What made it one or the other?

Is there suppressed disagreement on your current elder team — concerns that are being withheld because the culture has made it too costly to raise them? What would it take to surface them?

What does your elder team currently model to the congregation about how disagreement should be handled? Is that the model you want the congregation to see?

Can you identify a disagreement from your team's history that produced a better outcome because it was engaged

THE INEVITABILITY AND GOODNESS OF ELDER  
DISAGREEMENT

CHAPTER TWO

# Common Sources of Elder Conflict

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**UNDERSTANDING WHERE IT COMES** from before you try to address it

Elder conflicts that are addressed without being understood rarely resolve. The elder team that goes straight from conflict to resolution — without taking time to genuinely understand what the conflict is actually about — may achieve a temporary ceasefire, but the underlying issue remains and will resurface under different circumstances.

Most elder conflicts have more than one source. What presents as a disagreement about a specific decision is often also a disagreement about philosophy of ministry, or a manifestation of an unresolved relational tension, or the expression of a deeper anxiety about the church's direction. Learning to identify the layers of a conflict is the first step toward addressing it at the level where it actually lives.

## **THEOLOGICAL AND PHILOSOPHICAL**

**THE MOST SUBSTANTIVE CATEGORY** of elder conflict involves genuine theological or philosophical differences about what the church should be and do. These disagreements matter. They deserve serious, sustained engagement. And they are often more common on elder teams than pastors expect, precisely because the process by which elders are selected does not always include thorough exploration of their theological and philosophical commitments.

Secondary doctrinal disagreements — differing views on baptism, spiritual gifts, eschatology, or ecclesiological polity — can create genuine friction on elder teams, particularly when they affect how members approach specific ministry decisions. The elder who is cessationist and the elder who is continuationist will approach questions about healing prayer and prophetic gifts differently. The elder with Baptist convictions and the elder with Presbyterian commitments will approach questions about infant dedication and membership processes differently. These are not irreconcilable differences in every case, but they require honest conversation and agreed-upon frameworks for how they will be navigated.

More significant than secondary doctrinal disagreements are philosophy of ministry disagreements — differences in how elders understand what the church should look like, how it should engage the culture, what its worship should sound like, and what its priorities should be. These disagreements are sometimes more heated than doctrinal ones precisely because they are less easily resolved by appeal to Scripture. They involve judgment, context, experience, and

When theological or philosophical disagreements are the source of elder conflict, the most helpful response is to name them clearly. Not “We disagree about this decision” but “We disagree about this decision because we hold different views about what the church should be doing in this cultural moment.” That clarity does not resolve the disagreement, but it focuses the conversation at the level where the disagreement actually lives and makes productive engagement possible.

## RELATIONAL AND PERSONAL CONFLICT

**NOT ALL ELDER CONFLICT** is about theology or ministry philosophy. Some of it is simply relational — the product of personal chemistry that has not developed into genuine trust, unresolved offenses from earlier interactions, generational differences in communication style, or the accumulated irritations of people who share significant responsibility and see each other frequently.

Relational conflict on an elder team is often the most difficult to address because it is the most difficult to name. It feels too petty to raise formally. The elder who is genuinely bothered by a colleague’s communication style may not feel authorized to bring it to the team’s attention, and the elder who holds a grievance from a previous meeting may not know how to address it without sounding small. So the relational friction continues beneath the surface, coloring every subsequent interaction and creating an atmosphere of guardedness that undermines the team’s ability to be genuinely honest.



This conversation requires courage. It also requires the kind of relationship within the elder team that makes courage possible — a relationship of sufficient trust and genuine mutual regard that the conversation can happen without either party feeling attacked or ashamed. Building that kind of relationship is the work of the elder team's relational culture. The chapter on building healthy elder team relationships addresses how.

## **POWER AND INFLUENCE DYNAMICS**

**A CATEGORY OF ELDER** conflict that is rarely named but frequently present is the conflict driven by power and influence dynamics within the team. Elder teams have informal hierarchies — men whose voices carry more weight, whose history with the church gives them more social authority, whose institutional position or personal charisma makes them more influential than others. These dynamics are not inherently problematic. But they become problematic when they are unacknowledged, when they suppress the voices of less-prominent team members, or when an influential elder uses his position to

The senior pastor who dominates every elder meeting — whose vision is always the starting point, whose preferences always shape the outcome, whose authority is never genuinely questioned — is not leading an elder team. He is presiding over a group of advisors whose function is to affirm rather than genuinely oversee. This is a power dynamic that serves the pastor's comfort while undermining the purpose of plural eldership.

Equally problematic is the longtime elder whose tenure gives him a kind of informal veto over the team's direction. His disagreement is taken more seriously than others' because of how long he has been there. His preferences shape decisions not because of the quality of his arguments but because of the social cost of opposing him. This elder may be entirely well-intentioned — but his disproportionate influence is producing decisions that reflect his judgment rather than the team's shared discernment.

Naming power dynamics explicitly — “I notice that some voices on our team seem to carry more weight than others in our discussions. Is that our intention?” — is one of the most constructive things a senior pastor or a healthy elder team member can do. The conversation that follows may be uncomfortable. But it is far preferable to the accumulated dysfunction of a team that has never examined its own authority structures.

#### REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What are the primary sources of current or recent conflict on your elder team? Are they theological, relational, or driven by power dynamics — or some combination?

Are there power dynamics on your elder team that are suppressing genuine voices or producing decisions that reflect personal authority rather than shared discernment?

What unresolved relational tensions are present on your team right now? What would it take to address them directly?

### CHAPTER THREE

# How to Disagree Well

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**THE PRINCIPLES AND PRACTICES** that make conflict productive

The capacity to disagree well is not a personality trait. It is a set of principles that can be learned, practiced, and built into a team's culture. Some people find them more natural than others. But no one applies them automatically, and every elder team must cultivate them deliberately.

What follows is not a formula. It is a framework — a set of commitments that, when they are genuinely operative in an elder team's culture, make productive disagreement possible even in the most contentious circumstances.

## **PRINCIPLE ONE: SEPARATE THE ISSUE FROM THE PERSON**

**THE MOST FUNDAMENTAL PRINCIPLE** of productive disagreement is the consistent, deliberate separation of the issue being discussed from the person holding the opposing view. This sounds obvious. In practice, it is one of the most difficult disciplines in any sustained

The separation fails in both directions. The elder who disagrees with a colleague's proposal sometimes experiences that disagreement as a personal threat — as if the challenge to his idea is a challenge to his competence or his worth. And the elder who is raising the challenge sometimes experiences the colleague's resistance as a personal offense — as if the refusal to accept his argument is a refusal to respect his judgment.

When either of these failures occurs, the conversation has shifted from the issue to the relationship. And the issue — which is the actual thing that needs to be resolved — will not be resolved well until the relationship dynamic is addressed.

The discipline of separating issue from person requires the continuous, conscious application of a simple question: “Am I responding to the argument, or am I responding to who is making it?” If the honest answer is the latter, the conversation needs to be paused long enough to address the relational dynamic before the substantive issue can be productively engaged.

## **PRINCIPLE TWO: MAKE THE STEEL MAN, NOT THE STRAW MAN**

**A STRAW MAN ARGUMENT** is a weakened, distorted version of an opposing position that is easier to defeat than the real thing. It is the most common failure mode in disagreement, and it is particularly common among intelligent, articulate people who are confident in their own positions.

The antidote is the steel man: the practice of constructing the strongest possible version of the opposing argument

An elder team that practices steel-manning disagreement will sound different from most elder teams. Before challenging a colleague's position, the challenging elder articulates that position back to his colleague in the clearest, most charitable terms he can manage. "If I understand your concern correctly, you are arguing that... and the reason you find that compelling is... Is that a fair representation?" This practice serves two purposes. It demonstrates genuine respect for the colleague's position. And it frequently produces a correction — "That's close, but what I'm actually saying is..." — that prevents the team from arguing against a position no one actually holds.

### **PRINCIPLE THREE: SPEAK DIRECTLY, NOT TRIANGULARLY**

**TRIANGULATION IS THE PRACTICE** of expressing disagreement with person A through a conversation with person B. It is the most common form of relational cowardice in church life, and it is extraordinarily common on elder teams.

The elder who is bothered by a colleague's proposal does not raise his concern in the meeting where it could be addressed. He raises it afterward with another elder, or in a phone call with a trusted member of the congregation, or in the parking lot conversation that continues after the meeting ends. This is triangulation. And whatever its intention — processing, seeking counsel, building a coalition — its effect

The commitment to direct speech means that concerns about a colleague's position, behavior, or decision are raised first with that colleague, in private, with the express intention of resolving them. Not after the fact, not through intermediaries, not in the parking lot. The Matthew 18 principle applies to elder relationships as much as to any other: if you have a concern about a brother, go to him directly.

This is demanding. It requires the courage to have uncomfortable conversations rather than the easier path of processing discomfort indirectly. But an elder team that is genuinely committed to direct speech will find that its conflicts resolve more quickly, its trust deepens more consistently, and its culture of honesty becomes one of its greatest assets.

#### **PRINCIPLE FOUR: REMAIN OPEN TO BEING WRONG**

**EVERY ELDER WHO ENTERS** a disagreement believing he is correct. That is normal — people rarely advocate for positions they believe to be wrong. The question is whether the advocacy is held with the kind of epistemic humility that makes genuine persuasion possible.

The elder who is genuinely open to being wrong does several things differently from the elder who is merely going through the motions of engagement while waiting to win. He listens to the opposing argument with genuine attention rather than using the other person's speaking time to formulate his rebuttal. He acknowledges the strongest points

Openness to being wrong is not weakness. It is intellectual honesty. And it is one of the most powerful things an elder can model for his team — because the elder team that can say “I was wrong, and you were right” is a team that its pastor and congregation can genuinely trust to pursue truth rather than to protect position.

## **PRACTICAL TOOLS FOR PRODUCTIVE ELDER DISAGREEMENT**

### **THE PRE-MEETING CONVERSATION**

Many elder-meeting conflicts are avoidable if the parties involved have a preliminary conversation before the formal meeting. When a significant or potentially contentious decision is on the agenda, the senior pastor or the elder who will be making the proposal should contact the elders most likely to have concerns and have a direct, candid conversation about those concerns before the meeting.

This is not lobbying. It is not building a coalition before the formal discussion. It is the pastoral practice of making sure that the meeting can be productive by ensuring that the most significant concerns have already been surfaced and engaged at a level of depth that a group meeting setting rarely provides.

#### **The Timeout**

Every elder team needs a shared practice for calling a timeout when a meeting’s temperature is rising in a way that



The timeout is not a conflict avoidance strategy. It is a conflict quality strategy. The goal is to give everyone in the room enough of a reset to return to the conversation from a calmer and more productive place. And the conversation must resume after the break — a timeout that ends the discussion rather than pausing it is just a postponed conflict.

#### The Follow-Up Conversation

Not all elder disagreements can or should be resolved in the meeting where they first emerge. The commitment to resolve conflicts — which must be real — does not require resolving them immediately. Sometimes the most productive thing a team can do is agree that a significant disagreement requires more time, more information, or a different context, and commit explicitly to returning to it at a specified point.

The follow-up conversation that honors this commitment is essential. The elder team that consistently defers difficult conversations without ever returning to them will find that its most important unresolved questions accumulate until they reach a critical mass that produces the kind of explosion the deferral was designed to prevent.

#### REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Which of the four principles — issue/person separation, steel-manning, direct speech, openness to being wrong — is most lacking in your elder team's current culture? What would it look like to specifically cultivate it?

When did your team last have a significant disagreement that was handled well? What made it productive? Can you

Is there a pattern of triangulation on your elder team — concerns being raised indirectly rather than directly? What would it take to interrupt that pattern?

Does your team have shared practices — like the pre-meeting conversation or the timeout — for managing the dynamics of difficult discussions? What would you add?

#### CHAPTER FOUR

# When an Elder Becomes an Opponent

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**RECOGNIZING AND RESPONDING TO** a shift from disagreement to opposition

There is a meaningful difference between an elder who disagrees with you and an elder who has become your opponent. The first is a partner who holds a different view. The second is a person who has shifted from engaging the issue to pursuing an agenda — an agenda that may or may not be fully conscious to him, but that is oriented more toward undermining your leadership than toward the congregation's good.

This shift is one of the most disorienting things a pastor can experience, precisely because it often happens gradually and is not obvious until it has progressed significantly. The elder who was a genuine partner does not announce his opposition. He expresses increasing skepticism in meetings. He begins raising concerns about decisions after they have been made rather than before. He starts having conversations

## RECOGNIZING THE SHIFT

**THE SIGNS OF AN** elder moving from disagreement to opposition are specific enough that they can be recognized early if you are paying attention. The pattern almost always includes some combination of the following.

The elder begins consistently opposing rather than selectively disagreeing. Healthy disagreement is issue-specific. The elder who opposes the pastor's position on virtually every significant decision, regardless of the specific merits of each, is demonstrating something other than principled disagreement. He is demonstrating a posture of opposition.

The elder begins withholding information and support in ways that make your leadership more difficult. He does not share concerns in the meeting where they could be addressed — he expresses them afterward, to others, in ways that build skepticism of your leadership. He does not complete the commitments he made as part of a decision he opposed. He is slow to support publicly the decisions the team has made together.

The elder begins cultivating a following within the congregation. Not overtly — that would be too obvious. But through the conversations he has with specific members, through the concerns he expresses to people who share his networks, through the selective sharing of information that builds his credibility and undermines yours.

## THE DIRECT CONVERSATION

**THE MOST IMPORTANT RESPONSE** to an elder who is shifting into opposition is the direct, private, honest conversation. Not a confrontation. Not an accusation. A conversation that names what you have observed and invites genuine engagement with what is happening between you.

The conversation should have three elements. It should describe specifically what you have observed — not general impressions, but specific instances. “I want to talk honestly about a pattern I’ve noticed. In the last several months, I have observed...” Specificity matters because general accusations invite general denials. Specific observations require specific engagement.

It should invite the elder’s perspective genuinely — not rhetorically. “I’m not saying my perception of this is necessarily accurate. But this is what I’ve observed, and I want to understand what’s driving it from your side.” The goal is not to win the conversation. The goal is to understand what is actually happening and to address it at the level where it lives.

And it should name what is at stake if the pattern continues — not as a threat, but as an honest description of the situation. “If this pattern continues, it will be increasingly difficult for us to function as genuine partners in the same

## WHEN THE CONVERSATION DOESN'T WORK

**THE DIRECT CONVERSATION SOMETIMES** resolves everything. The opposing elder genuinely did not realize how his behavior was being perceived. Or the conversation surfaces a specific grievance that, once addressed, removes the source of the opposition. Or the elder finds the naming of the pattern sufficient motivation to change it.

But sometimes the conversation does not work. The elder acknowledges the pattern but does not change it. Or he denies it in ways that are difficult to believe given the evidence. Or he uses the conversation as information to escalate the opposition rather than to address it.

When the direct conversation does not resolve the opposition, the next step is the involvement of the full elder team. Not as a tribunal — the goal is not to put the opposing elder on trial. But as the appropriate context for addressing a pattern of behavior that is affecting the whole team's ability to function. The Matthew 18 principle: when a private conversation does not resolve the issue, involve additional witnesses — in this case, the full elder team.

The elder team conversation is more difficult than the private one. The opposing elder now knows that his pattern of behavior has been formally raised. The other elders are being asked to weigh in on a conflict between two of their colleagues, which is an uncomfortable position. And the outcome — whatever it is — will affect every relationship on

But it is necessary. An elder who is operating in opposition to the senior pastor cannot continue to do so without affecting the entire team's culture and effectiveness. The team must be willing to address it collectively if individual engagement has failed.

### WHEN OUTSIDE HELP IS NEEDED

**THERE ARE ELDER CONFLICTS** that exceed the team's internal capacity to resolve. When the conflict has become factional — when members of the congregation have been recruited into the opposition, when the relationship between the senior pastor and the opposing elder has become genuinely adversarial, when the team's ability to function has been significantly impaired — outside help is not just appropriate. It is necessary.

What does outside help look like? At minimum, it is a trusted pastor, denominational leader, or church consultant who has the relational standing and institutional independence to speak honestly to both parties. Ideally, it is someone with specific experience in church mediation — someone who knows how these dynamics develop, what the common failure modes are, and what resolution requires.

The willingness to seek outside help when internal resolution has failed is a sign of institutional health, not weakness. The elder team that refuses to seek help because it would require admitting the problem to someone outside the team is prioritizing its own reputation over the congregation's welfare. That is precisely the failure of leadership the outside help is designed to prevent.

### REFLECTION QUESTIONS

What prevented you from having the direct conversation sooner? What would make that conversation easier to initiate?

Does your elder team have a shared understanding of what to do when a direct conversation between two elders fails to resolve a conflict? Is that pathway clear and agreed upon?

Is there a situation on your current elder team that has exceeded your internal capacity to resolve? What has prevented you from seeking outside help?

## CHAPTER FIVE



# Making Decisions When Elders Are Divided

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**STRUCTURES AND PRACTICES FOR** reaching conclusions when consensus is elusive

One of the most practically urgent questions in elder conflict is also one of the least discussed: when elders genuinely disagree, how do you make a decision?

The question is urgent because elder teams must make decisions. Ministry cannot be permanently held in abeyance while the team works toward consensus that may never fully arrive. But it is poorly discussed because most church governance documents address the authority structures of elder decision-making without addressing the relational and spiritual dimensions of how decisions should actually be made.

The answer — like most good answers in church leadership — begins with theology and ends with practice.

**DECISION-MAKING MODELS: CONSENSUS**

**TWO PRIMARY MODELS GOVERN** how elder teams make decisions. The consensus model requires that decisions have the genuine agreement of all, or nearly all, elders before they are implemented. The majority model requires only that more than half the team agree. Both models have theological and practical considerations in their favor, and the choice between them is one that every elder team should make deliberately rather than by default.

The consensus model takes seriously the unity of the Spirit within the elder team. If God has assembled this specific group of men to oversee this specific congregation, the reasoning goes, then a decision that none of them can genuinely support is probably not a decision God is calling the church to make — at least not yet. Consensus models build in structural patience. They force extended conversation. They give minority voices real weight.

But consensus models can also be paralyzed by a determined minority. One elder who refuses to agree can prevent the team from ever implementing a necessary change. And the consensus culture can develop an informal veto that gives disproportionate power to the most resistant member of the team — which is precisely the opposite of the biblically balanced shared leadership the model is designed to produce.

The majority model is more decisive. It ensures that the team can actually govern, that decisions can be made, that ministry can move forward. But it creates winners and losers within the elder team. The elders who voted against a majority decision must decide whether they can support it,

Most healthy elder teams operate with an informal consensus preference and a formal majority fallback. They work toward genuine agreement, invest significant time in understanding and engaging minority concerns, and resist the impulse to call a vote until genuine effort toward consensus has been made. But they retain the capacity to make a decision by majority when consensus proves genuinely elusive and the ministry requires a resolution.

### **THE SENIOR PASTOR'S ROLE IN DIVIDED DECISIONS**

**ONE OF THE MOST** sensitive questions in elder decision-making involves the role of the senior pastor when the team is divided. In the purely collegial model of plural eldership, the senior pastor is simply one elder among equals, and his vote carries no more weight than any other elder's. In a more hierarchical model, the senior pastor may have a deciding vote or a de facto veto.

Neither extreme is fully satisfactory in practice. The senior pastor who has no more institutional authority than any other elder may find his leadership perpetually constrained by disagreements that the team cannot resolve. But the senior pastor who can simply override elder dissent has reduced his colleagues to advisors rather than genuine partners, which defeats the purpose of the shared leadership structure.

This division of authority is not always clean in practice. But the conversations required to define it — “What decisions belong to the elder team, and what decisions belong to the pastoral staff?” — are some of the most important conversations an elder team can have. The team that has clearly defined these boundaries before a crisis will navigate the crisis far more effectively than the team that is defining them in the middle of one.

## WHEN TO INVOLVE THE CONGREGATION

**SOME DECISIONS THAT DIVIDE** the elder team must eventually come to the congregation. The question of when to involve the congregation, and how, is one of the most delicate in divided-team decision-making.

The congregation should be involved when the decision directly affects the congregation’s life in ways that constitute a change to what they have agreed to as members. A significant change to the worship style, a major financial commitment that requires congregational sacrifice, a directional shift in the church’s mission — these are decisions

The congregation should not be involved as a way of appealing over the elder team's head. The senior pastor who brings a decision to the congregation because the elder team would not approve it is undermining the elder team's authority in a way that will damage the team's trust and the congregation's confidence in its leadership structure. Unless there is a genuine matter of congregational authority at stake — not merely the pastor's preferred outcome — the congregation is not the appropriate court of appeal for an unresolved elder disagreement.

### **IMPLEMENTING DECISIONS THE TEAM DOESN'T FULLY SUPPORT**

**WHEN A DECISION HAS** been made — whether by consensus or by majority — the responsibility of every elder on the team is to support that decision in a way that reflects the team's unity, regardless of how they voted.

This is not intellectual dishonesty. It is covenantal faithfulness. The elder who voted against a majority decision is not required to pretend he agreed with it. But he is required to honor the team's decision-making process, to refrain from working against the decision once it has been made, and to represent the team's direction to the congregation in a way that reflects the team's unity rather than his personal reservation.

The elder who cannot do this has reached the boundary of his ability to serve on this particular team, and that boundary needs to be named honestly — both for the team's sake and for his own.

What decision-making model does your elder team use? Is it the product of deliberate choice, or has it developed by default? Does it serve the team's health and effectiveness?

How is the senior pastor's role in divided-team decision-making defined in your context? Is that definition clear and agreed upon, or is it a source of ongoing tension?

Has your team brought a decision to the congregation when the elder team was divided? Was that the right call? What would you do differently?

Are there any current elders who are not supporting team decisions after they have been made? Has that pattern been addressed directly?

## CHAPTER SIX

# Rebuilding After Elder Conflict

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**REPAIRING WHAT CONFLICT DAMAGES** and building what prevents the next crisis

Elder conflict leaves marks. Even when it is resolved, the relationships that carried it are not immediately restored to their pre-conflict state. The trust that was strained does not automatically return. The patterns that emerged under pressure do not automatically disappear. And the culture that allowed the conflict to develop does not change simply because the specific conflict has been addressed.

The work of rebuilding after significant elder conflict is therefore a distinct phase of the process — not an epilogue, but a genuine and demanding continuation of the leadership work the conflict required. It involves repairing specific relationships, rebuilding team culture, and making the structural changes that will reduce the likelihood of similar conflicts in the future.

**THE MOST PERSONAL DIMENSION** of post-conflict rebuilding is the repair of the individual relationships that were damaged. This repair cannot be declared by a formal resolution or manufactured by a team retreat. It is built through the slow accumulation of small acts of genuine regard — the direct apology, the honest conversation, the consistent follow-through on commitments, the patient willingness to let trust rebuild at its own pace.

Apologies on elder teams are harder than apologies in most relationships. The institutional stakes are higher, the public accountability is greater, and the cultural permission for genuine vulnerability is often lower. An elder who apologizes to a colleague for his role in a conflict is taking a genuine risk — the risk of being perceived as weak, of having his admission used against him, of the apology being received without genuine reciprocation.

These risks are real. But the alternative — a team that moves forward from conflict without genuine relational repair, that maintains a surface appearance of professional collegiality while the underlying damage continues to affect every interaction — is worse. The team that cannot apologize is the team that cannot rebuild.

The discipline of apology in an elder context requires the same specificity that good feedback requires. “I apologize for the way I handled myself in that conversation. Specifically, I said things that were designed to be hurtful rather than honest, and that was wrong.” Not “I’m sorry if anything I said bothered you,” which is not an apology. Not “I was wrong, but you were also wrong,” which is a negotiation. A genuine,



## THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN FORGIVENESS AND RESTORED TRUST

**ONE OF THE MOST** important theological and practical distinctions in post-conflict elder relationships is the distinction between forgiveness and restored trust. These are not the same thing. They do not happen on the same timeline. And confusing them produces either premature trust that is not yet warranted, or false guilt about the absence of trust that has not yet been rebuilt.

Forgiveness is a choice. It is the decision not to hold an offense against the person who committed it, not to use it against them, not to allow it to permanently define the relationship. Forgiveness is given unconditionally, because that is how the gospel gives it. It does not require the other person's repentance. It is not contingent on the repair of the relationship. It is a gift, offered freely, in response to the forgiveness we ourselves have received.

Trust is rebuilt. It is the product of consistent, honest, faithful behavior over time. It cannot be manufactured or demanded. It is earned by the repeated demonstration, in low-stakes and high-stakes situations, that a person's word can be relied upon, that their motivations are genuinely what they appear to be, and that the patterns that damaged the relationship have genuinely changed.

An elder team that has been through significant conflict can forgive relatively quickly. The rebuilding of trust will take much longer — months or years, depending on the severity of the breach. That is not failure. It is the honest accounting of

## REBUILDING THE TEAM'S CULTURE

**INDIVIDUAL RELATIONSHIP REPAIR IS** necessary but not sufficient for post-conflict rebuilding. The team's culture — the shared values, norms, and practices that shape how the team functions — also needs to be examined and often rebuilt in the aftermath of significant conflict.

The most useful starting point for cultural rebuilding is an honest assessment of what the conflict revealed about the team's culture. Did the conflict happen because the team had no shared practice for raising and engaging concerns before they became crises? Did it happen because the team's relational investment had been insufficient to sustain honest disagreement? Did it happen because the team's decision-making structures were ambiguous enough that a conflict about authority could develop without resolution?

Each of these diagnoses points toward a specific cultural building project. A team that lacked a shared practice for raising concerns early needs to develop one — a norm about how and when concerns are raised, and a commitment to taking them seriously when they are. A team whose relational investment was insufficient needs to build more — through retreats, through regular informal time together, through the kind of honest personal sharing that the annual team retreat is designed to produce.

**EVERY ELDER TEAM SHOULD** build into its annual rhythm a meaningful evaluation of its own health — not a performance review, but an honest conversation among the team about how the team itself is doing. Are trust levels healthy? Are there unaddressed tensions? Are the meeting rhythms producing the kind of engagement the team needs? Are individual elders feeling genuinely supported and genuinely challenged? Is the team's culture moving in the direction the team intends?

This conversation is best held in a low-stakes, off-site context — the annual elder retreat, a dinner outside the church building, any setting that reduces the institutional dynamics that can make honest self-assessment difficult. It should be facilitated with enough structure to ensure that every team member has a genuine voice, and held with enough relational warmth to allow genuine honesty to emerge.

The team that conducts this annual assessment honestly will catch developing tensions before they become significant conflicts. It will identify cultural patterns that are producing problems before those problems become crises. And it will demonstrate to its own members that their investment in the team's health is genuinely valued — not just their institutional performance, but the quality of their relationships with each other.

#### REFLECTION QUESTIONS

Is there any unrepaired relational damage from past elder conflicts on your team? What is preventing the repair? What would it take to initiate it?

How does your team practice the distinction between

What did the last significant conflict on your team reveal about your team's culture? Are you building toward a culture that would handle similar situations differently?

Does your team have an annual health check — a structured, honest evaluation of how the team itself is doing? If not, what would it take to add one?

# Conclusion: The Unity That Is Worth Fighting For

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**THE GOAL OF THIS** book has not been to help elder teams avoid conflict. The goal has been to help elder teams handle conflict in a way that makes them stronger rather than weaker, that deepens trust rather than eroding it, and that produces better decisions rather than worse ones.

That goal is worth fighting for. Not fighting against each other — fighting for the kind of team culture that makes productive disagreement possible. Fighting for the relational depth that makes honest conversation safe. Fighting for the shared commitment to the congregation's good that keeps the team's disagreements from becoming personal. Fighting for the humility that can say "I was wrong" and the courage that can say "I think you're wrong" with equal readiness.

Elder teams that function this way are rare. They are also

It does not happen automatically. It is built — through years of relational investment, through the hard work of conflict addressed and resolved, through the slow accumulation of trust that only comes from consistent faithfulness. But it is built. It is possible. And it is worth whatever it costs to pursue it.

Finally, brothers, rejoice. Aim for restoration, comfort one another, agree with one another, live in peace; and the God of love and peace will be with you. — 2 Corinthians 13:11

The God of peace will not abandon the elder team that is genuinely trying to pursue the peace he calls them to. That is a promise worth holding onto in the middle of the meeting where everything seems to be falling apart.

Hold onto it.